DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Five Stages of God's Judgment in History

Daat Tevunot §146-150

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §146-150
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Wednesday 5 July 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Going over it again

On Monday the five levels were covered very quickly, so the Rabbi went back to the middle of §146, at the paragraph beginning "Nahzor leinyanenu". He reminded the group that judgment is necessary and good, because it means our actions have consequences. Part 2 of Section 7 now describes five levels of how far Hashem's judgment is revealed. They are not in chronological order.

Level 1: the first 2,000 years

There was almost no judgment at all, and it was concealed to the point of not operating. This is the worse kind of hester: no punishment, so evil simply builds up. On the surface the wicked prospered and everything ran smoothly, but evil kept growing. People knew the sun, the stars and their idols, but nobody knew God. The period runs roughly from creation until Avraham and on to the exodus. The Ramhal counts Egypt as its climax.

Level 2: now

From the destruction of the Temple until Mashiah there are no prophets and no miracles, but there is more knowledge of God. We have the Torah, which "we will have forever, thank God", and God's name is known among the nations. So it is not called tohu. Judgment does operate, though in the background, and sometimes it looks as though "there is no judgment and no judge". It is there but not revealed.

Level 3: the Temple era

At this level Hashem ruled openly with signs and wonders, so that all would know He is the God of Israel. But this is only revelation "from the outside". People recognised God through miracles, and without them their faith would not have been clear.

The Rabbi stressed that Judaism has never built faith on miracles. A maidservant at the sea saw more than the later prophets, because what she saw was internal. The Rambam rules that if a prophet performs miracles but tells you to break the Torah, he is put to death. Miracles help, but on their own they are not enough. Today, the Rabbi added, a cynic can explain away

any miracle, and he said he does not believe most of the miracle stories people tell him. Even if the splitting of the sea is explained scientifically, God is behind the science, and the perfect timing is itself the intervention.

Level 4: knowledge, as at Sinai

At the fourth level Hashem reveals Himself through knowledge, not miracles. "The earth shall be full of the knowledge of Hashem." This is what Israel attained at Har Sinai: "face to face Hashem spoke with you", and "they will believe in you forever". Faith that rests on a miracle can be shaken whenever the miracle is doubted. Knowledge leaves no doubt.

The Rabbi gave an analogy. If you show me a great miracle and then tell me two and two is four, I believe you because of the miracle. But if I work out for myself that two and two is four, I need no miracle. That is a far higher level. He linked it to prophecy as they had learned it: the essence of nevuah is the prophet's certainty that he is speaking with the Almighty. The other prophets fell to the ground and lost their senses because of this. Only Moshe could stand and speak "as a man speaks with his friend".

Level 5: constant elevation

The fifth level comes after the full revelation, from the time of Mashiah onwards. Man and his understanding are raised higher and higher, and the more he is raised, the more he understands of God's greatness and of how everything ran according to His plan. The Rabbi noted that free choice continues even then, but it is a choice between good and better.

A participant asked how anyone could sin with such clear knowledge, when Israel sinned forty days after Sinai. The Rabbi answered that humans forget, but after the 6,000 years "it's there in front of you".

So in historical order the levels go 1, 4, 3, 2 and then 5. A participant suggested that before 5 there may be a return to 4, or a time of miracles like level 3 in the days of Mashiah, and the Rabbi agreed this was probable.

The same five levels in a human life

The Ramhal then shows (§147-150) that a person's development follows the same pattern. The Rabbi said he likes to bring theory down to what we see in life, as he did with body and soul.

Hashem could have created man complete, yet a newborn is deficient and grows gradually:

1. In the womb for nine months, the person exists only in potential.
2. After birth he is there, but undeveloped.
3. At bar or bat misvah (13 for a boy, 12 for a girl) comes the first real maturity. A beit din punishes from 13, but in Heaven one is only punished from 20.
4. At 20 a person is fully developed.
5. After that, experience keeps growing. That is why one stands up for a 70-year-old, even an ignorant one, because he has the experience of life.

The Ramhal adds (§150) that every creature reflects one of Hashem's modes, which is why the prophets' visions include the lion, the ox and the eagle. The Rabbi said frankly that the Ramhal

does not explain how, "and I've got no idea how".

The plan was to finish Section 7 in the remaining classes before the summer break. There was no shiur the next evening because of the fast.

Summary

- Level 1 (the first 2,000 years): judgment in potential only, and evil builds up unchecked.
- Level 2 (now): Torah but no miracles. Judgment operates, but hidden.
- Level 3 (the Temple era): miracles reveal judgment, but only from the outside.
- Level 4 (Sinai): inner knowledge of God, beyond any doubt. Level 5 (after Mashiah): ever-growing elevation and understanding.
- A human life mirrors the five levels: womb, birth, 13, 20 and the experience of old age.

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